送错的快递

一座楼里的邻居们

The Wrong Parcel

Neighbours in a city tower block

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Footnotes mark names, festival terms and words above HSK 3 (HSK 3.0 lists: github.com/ivankra/hsk30, MIT).

1 城市里有很多这样的高楼：三十层，住着好几百个人。每天，快递员[†]都要送来几百个快递[‡]。可是住在一座楼里的人，很多都互相不认识。有的人在这里住了十年，还不知道对门住的是谁。黄阿姨[§]就住在这样一座楼的十二层。

1206还是1602?

2 黄阿姨今年六十五岁，以前是中学的数学老师，已经退休五年了。她的女儿在国外工作，一年只回来一次，所以家里常常只有她一个人。那天下午，她刚从外面回来，就看见门口放着一个很大的快递。她以为是女儿在网上给她买的东西，心里很高兴。

3 她拿起快递看了看，上面写着：1602，赵杰[¶]。原来，快递员把“1602”看成[*]了“1206”。

† 快递员 *kuàidìyuán* courier, delivery person
‡ 快递 *kuàidì* parcel (express delivery)
§ 黄阿姨 *Huáng āyí* Auntie Huang
¶ 赵杰 *Zhào Jié* Zhao Jie
* 看成 *kànchéng* to mistake for

Cities are full of tower blocks like this one: thirty floors, with several hundred people living in them. Every day, couriers bring in hundreds of parcels. Yet many of the people living in the same building don't know each other. Some have lived there for ten years and still don't know who lives across the hall. Auntie Huang lived on the twelfth floor of just such a building. 1

1206 or 1602?

Auntie Huang was sixty-five. She had been a secondary-school maths teacher and had been retired for five years. Her daughter worked abroad and came home only once a year, so most of the time she was on her own. That afternoon, she had only just got back when she saw a very large parcel sitting outside her door. She thought it was something her daughter had bought for her online, and she was very pleased. 2

She picked up the parcel and looked at it. On it was written: 1602, Zhao Jie. So the courier had mistaken "1602" for "1206". 3

3 黄阿姨[†]笑了：“数字倒过来了。这个快递员[‡]，数学一定不好。”快递[§]上有赵杰[¶]的电话，她打了两次，都没有人接。她想：放在这里，他找不到；放在楼下，又怕被别人拿错。只有自己送上去，她才放心。“反正我也没什么事，就当出去走走吧。”她拿着快递进了电梯[*]，按了“16”。

楼上的年轻人

4 1602的门关着。黄阿姨在门外问了好几次：“有人吗？你的快递！”过了很久，门才开了一点儿。一个年轻人站在门后，头发很乱，穿着睡衣，眼睛红红的，好像很久没睡觉了。“您……找谁？”“你是赵杰吧？这是你的快递，送到我家去了。我住1206。”

† 黄阿姨 *Huáng āyí* Auntie Huang
‡ 快递员 *kuàidìyuán* courier, delivery person
§ 快递 *kuàidì* parcel (express delivery)
¶ 赵杰 *Zhào Jié* Zhao Jie
* 电梯 *diàntī* lift, elevator

Auntie Huang laughed. "The numbers are back to front. This courier must be bad at maths." Zhao Jie's phone number was on the parcel. She rang it twice, but nobody answered. She thought: if I leave it here, he won't find it; if I leave it downstairs, someone might take it by mistake. Only if I take it up myself can I stop worrying. "I've got nothing else to do anyway. I'll call it a little walk." She carried the parcel into the lift and pressed "16". 3

The Young Man Upstairs

The door of 1602 was shut. Auntie Huang called out several times from outside: "Anyone home? Your parcel!" After a long time, the door opened just a little. A young man stood behind it, his hair a mess, wearing pyjamas, his eyes red, as if he hadn't slept in ages. "Can I... help you?" "You're Zhao Jie, aren't you? This is your parcel. It was delivered to my flat. I live in 1206." 4

5 赵杰[†]有点儿不好意思，把快递[‡]接了过去：“谢谢您，阿姨[§]。我刚才在睡觉，没听到电话。”“下午三点还在睡觉？”“我是写程序[¶]的。”赵杰说，“只有到了夜里，外面安静下来，我才能好好工作。所以我常常白天睡觉，晚上工作。”黄阿姨[*]往房间里看了看：桌子上有三台电脑，地上放着很多吃完的外卖。“你多久没出门了？”赵杰想了想：“一个星期吧。买东西、吃饭，在手机上点一下，就有人送来，反正不用出门。”那个很大的快递里，是二十包方便面。

6 黄阿姨看着那些方便面，就像看着班上不好好学习的学生。“年轻人，天天吃这个，身体会不好的。”赵杰笑了笑，没说什么。他心里想：这位阿姨比我妈还爱管。黄阿姨走了以后，他关上门，回到电脑前，很快就忘了这件事。

† 赵杰 *Zhào Jié* Zhao Jie
‡ 快递 *kuàidì* parcel (express delivery)
§ 阿姨 *āyí* auntie (polite address)
¶ 程序 *chéngxù* computer program
* 黄阿姨 *Huáng āyí* Auntie Huang

Zhao Jie looked a little embarrassed as he took the parcel from her. "Thank you, auntie. I was asleep just now and didn't hear the phone." "Still asleep at three in the afternoon?" "I write computer programs," said Zhao Jie. "Only at night, when it's quiet outside, can I really get any work done. So I usually sleep in the day and work at night." Auntie Huang glanced into the room: there were three computers on the desk and lots of empty takeaway containers on the floor. "How long is it since you went out?" Zhao Jie thought about it. "About a week. Shopping, food: you just tap your phone and someone brings it. You never have to go out anyway." The big parcel turned out to hold twenty packets of instant noodles. 5

Auntie Huang looked at the instant noodles the way she used to look at pupils in her class who didn't study properly. "Young man, if you eat this every day, it'll ruin your health." Zhao Jie smiled and said nothing. He thought: this auntie is even bossier than my mum. After she left, he shut the door, went back to his computer, and soon forgot all about it. 6

又送错了

7 可是没过三天，快递[†]又送错了。这一次是一些水果，上面还是写着“1602”。黄阿姨[‡]又送了上去。又过了几天，事情倒过来了：赵杰[§]的门口出现了一个小快递，上面写着“1206黄”。赵杰本来想先放着，可是他看到快递是从药店送来的。他想：要是阿姨[¶]正等着吃这个药呢？只有马上送下去，他才放心。他换了衣服，一个星期来第一次在白天走出了家门。

8 黄阿姨开门看见他，很高兴：“快进来坐！我正在包饺子。”赵杰本来想放下药就走，可是饺子太香了。他一口气[*]吃了二十多个，这是他这个月吃得最好的一顿饭。吃饭的时候，黄阿姨拿出手机：“小赵[#]，你帮我看看。我女儿给我发了一些照片，我怎么都打不开。”

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‡ 黄阿姨 *Huáng āyí* Auntie Huang
§ 赵杰 *Zhào Jié* Zhao Jie
¶ 阿姨 *āyí* auntie (polite address)
* 一口气 *yīkǒuqì* in one go
小赵 *Xiǎo Zhào* young Zhao (Zhao Jie)

Wrong Again

But less than three days later, a parcel went to the wrong flat again. This 7
time it was some fruit, and once again it said "1602". Auntie Huang took it up again. A few days later, it happened the other way round: a small parcel turned up outside Zhao Jie's door, addressed to "1206 Huang". Zhao Jie was going to leave it for the time being, but then he saw it had come from a pharmacy. He thought: what if she's waiting to take this medicine? He wouldn't feel easy unless he took it down straight away. He changed his clothes and, for the first time in a week, stepped out of his flat in daylight.

When Auntie Huang opened the door and saw him, she was delighted. 8
"Come in and sit down! I'm just making dumplings." Zhao Jie had meant to drop off the medicine and leave, but the dumplings smelled too good. He ate more than twenty in one go: the best meal he'd had all month. As they ate, Auntie Huang took out her phone. "Xiao Zhao, could you have a look? My daughter sent me some photos, and I can't get them to open, whatever I do."

8 赵杰[†]拿过手机，一分钟就弄好了。他又教她怎么在手机上叫车、买菜、跟女儿打电话的时候看到她的脸。黄阿姨[‡]说："你真是个好老师！我教了三十年书，今天才知道当学生这么难。"

9 第二天，两个人在楼下等到了那个快递员[§]。他叫小马[¶]，二十岁，从农村来，在这里送快递[*]才两个星期。他每天要送三百多个快递，一急就会看错数字。小马听说自己送错了三次，脸一下就红了："对不起，对不起！我以为……我以为我都看对了。"黄阿姨笑着说："没关系。要是你没有送错，我们两个住在一座楼里，可能永远也不会认识。"

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‡ 黄阿姨 *Huáng āyí* Auntie Huang
§ 快递员 *kuàidìyuán* courier, delivery person
¶ 小马 *Xiǎo Mǎ* Xiao Ma
* 快递 *kuàidì* parcel (express delivery)

Zhao Jie took the phone and sorted it out in a minute. Then he showed her how to call a taxi on her phone, buy groceries, and see her daughter's face when they talked. Auntie Huang said, "You're a really good teacher! I taught for thirty years, and only today have I learned how hard it is to be the student." 8

The next day, the two of them waited downstairs and caught the courier. His name was Xiao Ma. He was twenty, from the countryside, and had been delivering parcels here for only two weeks. He had over three hundred parcels to deliver every day, and whenever he was in a hurry he misread the numbers. When Xiao Ma heard he had got it wrong three times, he went red at once. "I'm sorry, I'm so sorry! I thought... I thought I'd read them all right." Auntie Huang smiled. "Never mind. If you hadn't got it wrong, the two of us might have lived in the same building forever without ever meeting." 9

一个新的群

10 那天晚上，赵杰[†]想了一个办法。他在手机上建了一个群，叫“我们这座楼”，把黄阿姨[‡]和小马[§]都拉了进来。他在群里说：“以后，谁收到了别人的快递[¶]，就把照片发到群里。反正大家都住在一座楼里，上楼下楼，几分钟就送到了。”黄阿姨叫来了自己认识的老人，赵杰也叫来了年轻的朋友。一个星期以后，群里已经有两百多个人了。

11 送错的快递，很快就能找到主人。可是大家在群里说的，早就不只是快递了。八楼一位老爷爷的手机坏了，十九楼的大学生下楼帮他修好了。二十楼的年轻妈妈晚上要工作，楼下的奶奶帮她去学校接孩子。黄阿姨每个星期六在家里教楼里的孩子们数学，一分钱也不要。她常常说：“楼再高，也只有大家互相认识了，才像一个家。”

† 赵杰 *Zhào Jié* Zhao Jie
‡ 黄阿姨 *Huáng āyí* Auntie Huang
§ 小马 *Xiǎo Mǎ* Xiao Ma
¶ 快递 *kuàidì* parcel (express delivery)

A New Group Chat

That evening Zhao Jie came up with an idea. He set up a group chat on 10
his phone called "Our Building" and added Auntie Huang and Xiao Ma to it. He wrote in the group: "From now on, if anyone gets someone else's parcel, just post a photo here. We all live in the same building anyway: up or down a few floors, and it's delivered in minutes." Auntie Huang brought in the older people she knew, and Zhao Jie brought in his young friends. A week later, the group had more than two hundred members.

Misdelivered parcels soon found their owners. But what people talked 11
about in the group had long since gone beyond parcels. When an old man on the eighth floor had trouble with his phone, a university student from the nineteenth floor came down and fixed it. A young mother on the twentieth floor had to work in the evenings, so a grandmother downstairs picked up her child from school for her. Every Saturday Auntie Huang taught maths to the building's children at her home, without charging a penny. She often said, "However tall a building is, it only feels like home once people know each other."

12 赵杰[†]呢？他成了群里最忙的人。谁的手机、电脑有问题，都来找他。他出门的时间越来越多，人也看起来精神多了。一个月以后，小马[‡]已经不送错了。每一个快递[§]上的数字，他都看两遍才放下。有一天，他在群里说：“这个月，我一个快递也没送错！”黄阿姨[¶]回答：“小马，谢谢你！”小马不明白：“谢我什么？我送错了那么多次。”“就是因为你送错了，我们才认识了啊。”

13 那天晚上，赵杰又收到了一个快递。这一次，数字写得很对，快递也送得很对。可是过了一会儿，他还是拿着两包面下了楼，来到1206门口。“黄老师，这次没有送错。”他笑着说，“我是来跟您学包饺子的。”黄阿姨笑着开了门：“进来吧。反正我一个人包的，也吃不完。”

† 赵杰 *Zhào Jié* Zhao Jie
‡ 小马 *Xiǎo Mǎ* Xiao Ma
§ 快递 *kuàidì* parcel (express delivery)
¶ 黄阿姨 *Huáng āyí* Auntie Huang

12 And Zhao Jie? He became the busiest person in the group. Anyone with a problem with their phone or computer came to him. He went out more and more, and he looked much livelier for it. A month later, Xiao Ma no longer made mistakes. He read the number on every parcel twice before he put it down. One day he posted in the group: "This month I haven't delivered a single parcel to the wrong place!" Auntie Huang replied: "Xiao Ma, thank you!" Xiao Ma didn't understand. "Thank me for what? I got so many wrong." "It's precisely because you got them wrong that we all met."

13 That evening Zhao Jie received another parcel. This time the number was correct, and the parcel had come to the right door. But a little later, he went downstairs anyway with two bags of flour and came to the door of 1206. "Teacher Huang, nothing's gone to the wrong place this time," he said with a smile. "I've come to learn how to make dumplings from you." Auntie Huang opened the door, smiling. "Come on in. I can never eat all the ones I make by myself anyway."